

Family strain

Religion and belief are very personal things, and an important part of a person's sense of self. It is natural for emotions to run high during religious discussions, and if a teen is experimenting with different religious ideas. What's important is for parents to respect their teen's individuality, and to provide a secure and open-minded environment in which a teen can explore their own spiritual identity or opinions.

TEEN HINTS

Conflict with parents

Both parents and teens can feel frustrated when their views differ. Understanding and respect on both sides is key. Ask your parents questions about their views and beliefs, and how they came to those beliefs. At the same time, be willing to answer any questions they ask you. You can agree to disagree, but it is important to show respect for each other's values and beliefs.

ALERT!

Extremism

An extremist is someone who holds extreme political or religious opinions, often advocating illegal or violent actions to support their cause. Extremists exploit a person's internal confusion by focusing exclusively on one aspect of their identity, such as their religion, and distorting it into something negative. Vulnerable individuals, such as teens undergoing their own process of self-discovery, are particularly susceptible to being swayed by extremist views through exposure to radical propaganda.

Other belief systems

For as long as there have been religions, there have been people with different worldviews.

Judaism

Originating 3,500 years ago, the teachings of this religion, compiled in the Jewish sacred text, the Torah, formed the basis for both Christianity and Islam. The 14 million Jews around the world believe that they share a special bond—a covenant—with God, passed on by the prophet Abraham.



Agnosticism

Agnostics question belief and certainty. They are sceptical of both religious and atheistic beliefs. They don't deny the existence of a god or gods, nor any supernatural beings—but they do deny that anyone can know for sure if such entities do or don't exist.



Sikhism

Founded by Guru Nanak in India's Punjab region in the 1400s, Sikhism shares aspects of Hinduism and Islam. Its 24 million followers believe in only one god and live life by three basic rules—pray, work, and give—and believe that being close to God is as much about a person's actions as it is about their belief.



Atheism

There are approximately 1 billion people in the world who are non-religious, and about half of those identify as atheist. Atheism means "without god," and atheists believe that the universe can be explained without a god, and that decent moral codes have social origins.

